were compelled by circumstances to take up arms and become a 'race of warriors' to defend their nation, faith, community, fertile lands and their freedom. Guru Arjan Dev's son, Hargobind, became the guiding force for developing Sikhs into a formidable martial community to protect the Sikh faith and beliefs. By the time of his death in 1644, Guru Hargobind had rallied the community and also formalized the institution of the gurdwara – 'the abode of the guru', the Sikh house of piety and prayer, with the Granth Sahib consecrated in it.

Under the Muslim rulers, especially during the reign of the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb, the Hindus and the Sikhs were the targets of many indignities as they were seen as 'kafirs' – non-believers. Forcible conversions were the order of the day. Guru Gobind Singh, the tenth guru, took a stand to protect the Kashmiri Pundits and others. He stands as a stoic symbol of unwavering faith and supreme sacrifice for a just cause. He is deferentially referred to as 'Sarbansh Daani', one who sacrificed his whole family – his father as well as four sons attained martyrdom. Two of his minor sons were 'bricked' alive in Sirhind when they refused conversion. It was Guru Gobind Singh who formalized the transformation of Sikhs into the Khalsa (the pure) or Singhs (lions). The guru ordained his followers to always possess the five 'K's: 'kesh', uncut hair and beard; 'kirpan', the sword; 'kara', the iron bangle; 'kanga', the comb; and the 'kachha', the shorts. In addition, the turban became an integral part of the Khalsa attire. Guru Gobind Singh composed 'deh shiva bar mohe', a classic 'baani' (spiritual words) in the form of a 'shabad' (devotional poetry), so as to inspire and motivate his Khalsa followers and the Sikhs to live by his principles, fight against injustice, be victorious in every endeavour, and when the time came, to lay down their lives fighting courageously. This remarkable transformation of peasants into warriors had a profound impact on the history of the Punjab.

Eventually, it was Guru Gobind Singh's vision and wisdom that just before his death in October 1708, he consecrated the 'Granth Sahib', as the eternal guru of the Sikh faith, the guiding force for personal and ethical conduct. The Guru Granth Sahib is the